

A second-century *salabhanjika yakshi* on a gatepost of the east gateway of Stupa 1 at Sanchi.

External historical sources support the legendary antiquity of these three dynasties. The Greek Megasthenes, appointed as ambassador to the Mauryan rulers of Northern India in about 310 BCE by the successor to Alexander the Great in Babylon, wrote of South India being governed by queens, with the ‘Pandae’ (Pandyas) and the ‘Charmae’ (Cheras) as rulers. Half a century later, the Buddhist emperor Ashoka Maurya declared in his famous major rock edicts that his Dharma, or Moral Law, extended ‘on its borders among the Chodas [Cholas], the Panidas [Pandyas], Satiputras, Keralaputras and as far as Tambrapani’ – which could refer to the river of that name but more probably to the island of Lanka, which the Greeks knew of as Taprobane.